actively sponsored the Buddhist hierarchy and the infrastructure of monasteries and temples, as the Theravada Buddhist theory of the just state required of its rulers.[5] Others, such as General Aung San,[6] argued that the new state should be inclusive and that all who lived within its borders were now to be seen as Burmese citizens. Within the army there was a different debate, between those who saw the role of the military in conventional ways (as the armed forces of a state but under civilian control) and people like Ne Win (the organiser of the 1962 coup) who wanted to see the military take control,[7] since they believed that only the army truly represented the Burmese people.

With the assassination of General Aung San in 1947,[8] these debates shifted in favour of those who wanted the new state to be an embodiment of Burman Buddhist beliefs and who believed that the military was 'the only institution that has discipline, loyalty, unity and deep commitment to protect the sovereignty and independence of the country'.[9] This in turn provoked some splits among the former independence movement, and some leaders, like Kyaw Zay, went into internal exile to lead the military wing of the Burmese Communist Party. Some members of the civilian government, including Aung San's wife, Khin Kyi,[10] continued to argue for a secular future for Burma. In effect, it was not until the military took power in 1962 that the logic of equating being Burmese with being Buddhist came to be deeply entrenched, and even then it was a gradual and incremental process.

The Burmese military, also known as the 'Tatmadaw', as a result came to see itself as the cornerstone of the new state. It also quickly came to the conclusion that it faced powerful internal threats,[11] especially now that it had chosen a sectarian, exclusivist definition of what being Burmese meant.

In reality there was some truth in the military's fears, but what was to come was also in part a consequence of the drastic measures it imposed out of little more than paranoia. By effectively telling those who wished for a secular Burma, or who came from non-Burman ethnic groups, that they were not proper members of the new state, it set the stage for a series of revolts. Shortly after independence, in March 1948, the Burmese Communist Party, possibly with Chinese backing,[12] launched a military campaign to bring down the new government.[13] By the early 1950s they had been beaten back but remained a significant military force, and were only driven out of central Burma in the early 1960s. In turn, the Karen